

LIGHT MACHINE-GUNS AND MACHINE-PISTOLS

Although rapid-fire weapons ruled the battlefields of World War I, they were far too cumbersome to be carried into attack. The first step was to abandon ammunition belts, water-cooling, and the impossibly heavy static mount for magazines, and adopt lighter barrels and the sort of “furniture” found on rifles. These innovations led to the light machine-gun (LMG), which was handy enough, just about, for a man to fire from the hip on the move. The next stage in the development of automatic weapons was a complete departure. The machine-pistol was an entirely new form of a much lighter weapon, firing pistol-calibre ammunition in bursts.



▲ LEWIS GUN M1914
Date 1913
Origin US
Weight 11.8kg (26lb)
Barrel 66cm (26in)
Calibre .303in

The air-cooled Lewis Gun was the first LMG used on the Western Front. Taken up by the Belgians, then by the British, it remained in service on the ground, in the air (when it was usually stripped of its barrel shroud), and even at sea until World War II.



▲ MG13
Date 1914
Origin Germany
Weight 10.9kg (24lb)
Barrel 71.7cm (28¼in)
Calibre 7.92mm Mauser

The MG13 was developed from a weapon Louis Schmeisser designed and Dreyse produced from 1909. That gun was water-cooled, but the MG13 swapped the water jacket for a perforated shroud, and gained a tubular butt stock and a pistol grip-and-trigger group.

Carrying handle

Perforated barrel



Butt plate



▲ MAXIM MG08/15
Date 1915
Origin Germany
Weight 14kg (30¾lb)
Barrel 71.9cm (28½in)
Calibre 7.92mm Mauser

To turn it into an LMG, the MG08's receiver was abbreviated and it got a slimmer water jacket, a bipod, a butt, and a pistol grip and trigger. Ammunition belts were contained in drums.

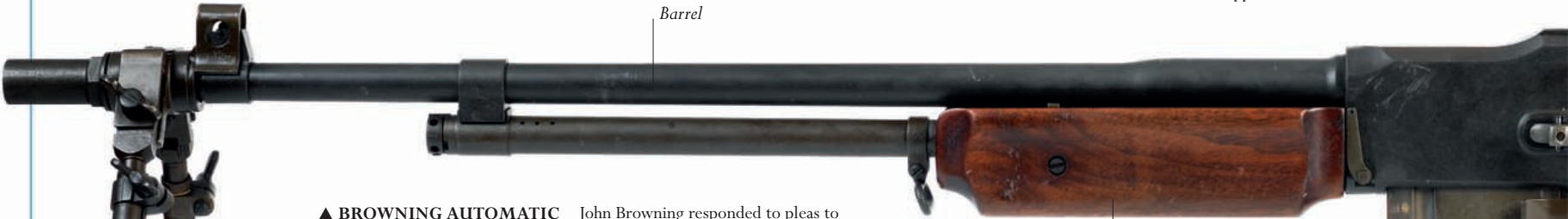
Wooden butt

Barrel



Trigger stabilizer

Support



▲ BROWNING AUTOMATIC RIFLE (BAR) M1918
Date 1918
Origin US
Weight 7.28kg (16lb)
Barrel 61cm (24in)
Calibre .30-06 Springfield

John Browning responded to pleas to provide infantrymen with a weapon they could fire in bursts from the hip while advancing. The gas-operated BAR was too heavy and cumbersome ever to be a success in that role, but it survived as the US Army's stock LMG until the 1950s.

Wooden fore end or handguard

20-round detachable magazine